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Date: 2/2/2026 at 12:00

Presentation by Aleksander Eskilson (No presentation name)

Summary

Aleksander Eskilson is a Staff Engineer at Oracle. His career revolved around Health Tech and Artificial Intelligence. He began by working with early versions of auto-encoders to address critical medical classification tasks like detecting aneurysms. He then changes jobs from from these early "wild" startups to the structured, high-stakes massive corporations.

The main point of the talk is the difference between operating as a Director in a startup versus a tech lead at a company like Oracle. Startups offer a broad reach across the codebase and require creative, rapid problem-solving. The downside is that they are often unstable and subject to the sudden shifts of "product-market fit". In contrast, big companies have significant administrative constraints and more overhead. But, it also provides the infrastructure to build larger platforms that serve entire populations.

The speaker also talks about responsible AI. Once a philosophical niche, it is now a rigorous branch of risk management. Fairness is defined through specific mathematical parameters like demographic equality of opportunity. The presentation concludes with a look at the current industry shift where software engineers are becoming "managers" of AI-driven coding tools. This evolution places a higher premium on technical leadership and high-level architectural planning over raw syntax knowledge. The presentation ends talking about the geopolitics of AI development. Specifically, the competition between regulated American labs and foreign Chinese labs.

What I learnt

One major takeaway is the redefinition of the Entry-Level Engineer. Aleksander suggests that modern tools have effectively promoted every new hire to a Senior role, where the primary task is overseeing AI-driven juniors. I learned that engineering is a deeply human discipline with a centuries-old tradition of trans-formative responsibility. I also learned that fairness in AI is not a subjective "feeling" but a measurable metric that companies use to mitigate media and legal risks. Understanding the tension between personal labor value and corporate "fungibility" is essential for long-term career survival.

What I will do different

I will focus my learning on high-level system design and architectural documentation instead of programming the projects themselves. I will hand over the programming to AI assistants and I

will focus on the skills of decomposition and delegation. I will focus on treating every prompt as a management task. To make sure that the program doesn't have security issues (AI's current main drawback), I will provide rigorous specifications and perform skeptical audits of the resulting code. My value will no longer be measured by how many lines of code I can write, but by how accurately I can orchestrate complex technical systems.

I will incorporate Responsible AI frameworks into my project planning from the start. This means using model cards and mathematical fairness checks to ensure my work doesn't just function correctly, but also behaves ethically across different demographics. This shift moves ethics from a post-development checklist to a core technical requirement.

I think most importantly, I will maintain a consistent pulse on the market and the state of the industry. After talking to him after class, I realized how software engineering is no longer linear and how much it has changed in the last 8 years (since he graduated). It is important to stay on top of things because falling behind could quickly lead to me being out of a job.